MODULE 25 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

Version Currency: 1.12 Against Today

What the exam tests, what you will actually download, and the rules that changed in between.

COVERS Cross-cutting EXAM VERSION Terraform 1.12 MODULE 25 of 27

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The exam is a **snapshot**. The documentation is not. Where they disagree, the exam wins.

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What the exam is pinned to

- **HashiCorp states the exam tests Terraform 1.12.** It is on the certification page, not inferred.
- **The official exam content list links to /v1.12.x/ documentation paths**, deliberately.
- So the pinning is not incidental. HashiCorp is telling you which documentation to revise from.
- **developer.hashicorp.com serves the latest version by default.** You have to select 1.12 yourself.
- That version selector is the single most useful thing on the site while revising.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Following a link from the exam content list gives you 1.12 docs. Searching the site gives you current docs. Two different answers.

The timeline

VERSION	RELEASED, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE
1.10	Ephemeral variables, outputs and resources. Examinable
1.11	Write-only arguments. S3 native locking GA. Examinable
1.12	The version this exam tests
1.13 and 1.14	Beyond the exam. 1.14 added list resources and terraform query
1.15	Dynamic module sources, variable deprecation, backend validation
1.16	Import blocks inside modules, a terraform_data store block

ON THE EXAM

Four minor versions separate the tested version from the current one. Terraform 1.16.1 was released on 2 September 2026.

Things you will meet that are not examinable

- **terraform query** and **list resources**, written in .tfquery.hcl files. Terraform 1.14.
- **actions blocks**, invoked with a flag. Terraform 1.14.
- **Dynamic module sources**, using a const attribute on a variable. Terraform 1.15.
- **Variable and output deprecation**, with a deprecated attribute. Terraform 1.15.
- **A store block in terraform_data**, holding ephemeral values across plan and apply. Terraform 1.16.

> ON THE EXAM
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> These are real features you will see in current documentation. None of them can appear as a correct answer on this exam.

Rules this course taught that later versions relaxed

- **Module fourteen:** a module source cannot use variables. **Relaxed in 1.15** with the const attribute.
- **Module nineteen:** import blocks sit in the root module. **Relaxed in 1.16**, which allows them inside modules.
- **Module six:** validate checks configuration structure. **Extended in 1.15** to validate the backend block too.
- **All three statements remain correct for 1.12**, which is what the exam asks about.
- This is what a version-pinned exam feels like from the inside. Answer for 1.12, and know why.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Three absolute-sounding rules in this course have exceptions in versions you can download today. None of them applies to the exam.

Things that ARE examinable and older material misses

- **Provider-defined functions**, called with a namespaced syntax. Terraform 1.8.
- **Cross-object variable validation**, referencing other variables and data sources. Terraform 1.9.
- **Ephemeral values** (1.10) and **write-only arguments** (1.11).
- **S3 native locking** with use_lockfile, GA in 1.11.
- Plus the four topics HashiCorp names as new in 004, which are modules eleven, twelve, thirteen and twenty-two.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> This is the more dangerous direction. A candidate revising from a 003-era guide will simply not have seen most of this.

Replaced, and still widely taught

OLDER MATERIAL SAYS	CURRENT ANSWER
terraform taint	-replace on plan or apply. Deprecated since 0.15.2
terraform refresh	-refresh-only mode. Deprecated since 0.15.4
S3 plus a DynamoDB lock table	use_lockfile, writing a .tflock object. DynamoDB deprecated
The remote backend for Terraform Cloud	The cloud block. Since Terraform 1.1
Terraform Cloud	HCP Terraform. Renamed in 2024
terraform state mv and state rm	moved and removed blocks, which appear in a plan

ON THE EXAM

Every left-hand entry still works. That is exactly why they survive in runbooks and study guides years after being superseded.

Ownership, naming and licensing

- **IBM completed its acquisition of HashiCorp in June 2024.** Operations transitioned in 2025.
- HashiCorp states **no features or functionality changed** as a result.
- **Terraform Cloud became HCP Terraform** in 2024. The 004 objectives use the new name.
- **Terraform is under the Business Source Licence** since 2023. Source-available, not open source.
- **OpenTofu** is the Linux Foundation fork. Not examinable, and worth knowing exists.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The exam uses HCP Terraform throughout. A question or a guide saying Terraform Cloud is describing the same product by an older name.

How to revise from the documentation safely

- **Start from the official exam content list**, and follow its links. They are pinned to 1.12.
- **Use the version selector** when you land on a page from a search. The default is current.
- **Watch for version notes.** Pages say when a feature arrived, which tells you if it is in scope.
- **Be sceptical of undated blog posts.** Most Terraform writing on the internet predates 1.10.
- **Check the changelog for anything you learn late.** One line tells you which release introduced it.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A documentation page that says a feature was added in 1.14 has answered the only question that matters for this exam.

Reading the scenario

YOU ENCOUNTER	WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE EXAM
A feature note saying 'added in 1.14'	Out of scope. It cannot be a correct answer
A guide recommending a DynamoDB lock table	Written before 1.11. Still works, not current
A page saying 'Terraform Cloud'	Older naming. The product is HCP Terraform
A claim that Terraform has no custom functions	Out of date since 1.8. Provider functions exist
A module source referencing a variable	Valid from 1.15. Not valid in 1.12
taint, or the refresh command	Deprecated. Recognise them; do not choose them

ON THE EXAM

The question to ask about any fact is which release it belongs to. Before 1.12 is in scope; after is not.

> A candidate revising from developer.hashicorp.com reads about list resources and the terraform query command, which discover existing infrastructure and can generate import configuration in bulk.
>
> It looks directly relevant to the import objective, and they plan to memorise it.

What should they do?

A. Memorise it. It is in the official documentation, so it is in scope

B. Note it as useful at work, and skip it. It arrived in 1.14, after the tested version

C. Memorise it, since import is an exam objective and this is part of importing

D. Skip the import objective entirely, since the documentation has changed

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should they do?

A Official, so in scope

The documentation covers the current release. Being official says nothing about which version a page describes.

B Note it, skip it

Correct. It arrived in 1.14, two releases after the tested version, so it cannot be a correct answer on this exam.

C Import is an objective

The objective is examined against 1.12 behaviour. A newer mechanism for the same task is still newer than the exam.

D Skip the objective

Overcorrects badly. The 1.12 import mechanisms - the command, import blocks, config generation - are all squarely examinable.

THE SIGNAL

Being in the documentation and being in scope are different tests. The version note on the page answers the second one.

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> A study guide bought second-hand teaches: use terraform taint to force replacement, create a DynamoDB table alongside an S3 bucket for locking, connect the CLI to Terraform Cloud with the remote backend, and notes that Terraform has no user-defined functions.
>
> A candidate asks which of these are still correct for the exam.

What is the accurate assessment?

A All four are correct. They are core Terraform behaviours

B All four are superseded, though each still describes something that works or once worked

C Only the DynamoDB advice is out of date. The rest are current

D All four are wrong and were never correct

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

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What is the accurate assessment?

A All four correct

Each was correct at some point, which is why the guide says them. Taint and the remote backend are deprecated, DynamoDB locking is deprecated, and provider functions exist since 1.8.

B All four superseded

Correct. taint gave way to -replace, DynamoDB to use_lockfile, the remote backend to the cloud block, and 1.8 added provider-defined functions.

C Only DynamoDB

Picks the best-known of the four. The other three are equally superseded, and the naming change alone dates the guide.

D Never correct

Unfair and unhelpful. Each was the documented recommendation in its day, which is exactly why they persist.

THE SIGNAL

The fourth item is the subtlest. 'No user-defined functions in HCL' is still true; 'no custom functions at all' stopped being true in 1.8.

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> A candidate sits the exam having also used Terraform 1.16 at work. A question asks how to make a module's source address vary by environment.
>
> At work they would use a variable marked const, which 1.15 introduced for exactly this.

How should they answer?

A Choose the const-based answer, since it is the modern approach

B Answer for 1.12: module sources take no variables, so use separate module blocks or a different structure

C Choose whichever option mentions a variable, since the question implies one is needed

D Skip the question, since the correct answer depends on the version

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should they answer?

A The modern approach

Correct at work on 1.15 or later, and wrong here. The exam tests 1.12, where a module source cannot reference a variable at all.

B Answer for 1.12

Correct. Knowing the newer feature exists is useful; answering with it on a version-pinned exam is not.

C Anything with a variable

Pattern-matching on a keyword rather than reading the options. It would likely select a distractor.

D Skip it

There is no negative marking and the 1.12 answer is knowable. Skipping a question you can answer is a guaranteed loss.

THE SIGNAL

Real experience with a newer version is an advantage everywhere except the few questions where the behaviour changed.

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Module 25 recap

- **The exam tests Terraform 1.12**, and the objectives link to 1.12 documentation deliberately.
- **The current release is four minor versions ahead.** Use the version selector when you search.
- **query, actions, const module sources and deprecation attributes are all out of scope.**
- **Provider functions, cross-object validation, ephemeral values and native S3 locking are in scope.**
- **taint, terraform refresh, DynamoDB locking and the remote backend are superseded**, and still widely taught.
- **Where current behaviour and 1.12 disagree, answer for 1.12**, and know that you are choosing to.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Three rules this course stated as absolute have exceptions in later versions. All three still hold for the exam.